

Designing a political simulator game

Phase 1: The Core Pillars (What to Simulate)

You cannot simulate everything. You must choose which "lens" your game uses. Is it a spreadsheet manager (*Democracy 4*) or a narrative RPG (*Suzerain*)? Regardless, you need these four pillars:

1. The Political Capital System

- **Concept:** You are not a god; you are a leader with limited influence. You need a resource that represents your ability to get things done.
- **The Mechanic:** Call it "Political Capital," "Authority," or "Influence."
 - **Earning it:** Winning elections, passing popular bills, or fulfilling campaign promises.
 - **Spending it:** Every action (firing a minister, proposing a controversial tax, ignoring a scandal) costs Capital. If you run out, you become a "lame duck" leader—unable to act even if the country is burning.

2. The Faction System (Interest Groups)

- **Concept:** A country is not one person; it is a collection of groups with conflicting needs.
- **The Mechanic:** Divide your population into overlapping groups.
 - *Examples:* Capitalists, Socialists, Religious Traditionalists, Liberals, Patriots, Minorities.
 - **The Hook: Overlapping Membership.** A single citizen might be a *Socialist* AND a *Religious Traditionalist*. If you pass a pro-religion law that hurts the poor, that citizen is conflicted. This prevents the game from being too binary (Good vs. Bad).

3. The Economic Web

- **Concept:** Politics is often just resource allocation.
- **The Mechanic:** You don't need to simulate every dollar, but you need **Flow**.
 - **Inputs:** Taxes (Corporate, Income, Sales), Tariffs, Exports.
 - **Outputs:** Military upkeep, Social Services, Infrastructure, Debt Interest.
 - **The Consequence:** High taxes = low private investment but high state budget. Low taxes = high private growth but crumbling infrastructure.

4. The Geopolitical Stage

- **Concept:** No country exists in a vacuum.
- **The Mechanic:**

- **Superpowers:** Create 1-2 massive nations that pressure the player. You either align with one (losing independence but gaining protection) or try to stay neutral (risking isolation).
 - **Trade:** Your economy should depend on imports/exports. If you anger a neighbor, they cut off your oil.
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Phase 2: Key Mechanics to Implement

The "Dilemma Engine"

Instead of a simple "Build Hospital" button, present choices as dilemmas with no perfect answer.

- *Scenario:* A new virus is spreading.
- *Option A:* Lockdown the country. (Health ++, Economy --, Liberty --)
- *Option B:* Keep open for business. (Health --, Economy ++, Capitalist Support ++)
- *Option C:* Mandatory masks. (Health +, Liberty --, Religious Support --)

The "Cabinet" Layer

You need intermediaries. You shouldn't micromanage every road repair; you appoint a Minister of Infrastructure.

- **Loyalty vs. Competence:** A competent minister might fix the economy but plot to replace you. A loyal minister might be incompetent and cause scandals.
- **Scapegoating:** When things go wrong, the mechanic should allow you to "fire" a minister to save your own approval rating.

The "Feedback Loop" (The Media)

Players need to know *why* they are failing.

- **The Mechanic:** Implement a "News Feed" or "Newspaper" system.
 - If you cut education funding, don't just show a stat drop. Show a headline: *"Teacher Strike Leaves 5,000 Children at Home."* This adds emotional weight to the numbers.
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Phase 3: How to Do It Well (Design Philosophy)

1. Avoid "spreadsheet fatigue"

- **The Trap:** Many political sims become staring at bar graphs.
- **The Fix: Visual Feedback.** If the economy is crashing, show closed storefronts on the map. If there are riots, show smoke. *Civilization* does this well; the map changes based on your stats.

2. The "Slippery Slope"

- Good political games tempt you into corruption.
- Don't make "becoming a dictator" a toggle button. Make it a survival mechanism.
 - *Example:* You are about to lose the election. The game offers you a choice: "Bribe the opposition leader?" It costs nothing but "Integrity." If you do it, you win, but now you represent a corrupt system.

3. Emergent Storytelling

- Don't script everything. Create systems that collide.
 - *System A:* Low Police Budget = High Crime.
 - *System B:* High Crime = Capitalists leave the country.
 - *Result:* You cut police funding to save money, but it caused a recession because all the business owners fled the crime wave. The player created this story, not the developer.

4. UI is King

- Political games die on their User Interface.
- **Nested Tooltips:** (Like in *Crusader Kings 3* or *Victoria 3*). If a player hovers over "GDP," it should show exactly what is raising it and what is lowering it. Never hide the math.

1. The Dashboard (Starting Stats)

Write these down on a piece of paper. This is the state of your country, "Republic of Prototypes."

Resources:

- **Treasury:** \$5 Billion (This is low; you are in debt)
- **Political Capital (PC):** 5 Points (Your ability to force decisions)

Faction Support (0-10 Scale):

- **Labor Unions:** 6/10 (Cautiously optimistic)
- **Oligarchs (Business):** 4/10 (Skeptical of you)
- **Military:** 5/10 (Neutral)

Global Meters:

- **Civil Unrest:** 2/10 (Calm)
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2. The Event Card

You draw a card from the "Crisis Deck".

EVENT: THE IMF DEMANDS REPAYMENT International lenders are demanding a payment of **\$4 Billion** immediately. You only have \$5 Billion.

Paying this will leave the treasury empty for essential services. Ignoring it will destroy your credit rating.

Objective: Solve the deficit without causing a coup or a riot.

3. The Decisions

Here are the choices available to you. Note how they interact with your **Resources** and **Factions**.

Option A: Austerity Measures

Slash public spending to pay the debt.

- **Financial Cost:** \$0
- **Political Capital Cost:** 1 PC (Requires whipping votes in parliament)
- **Outcomes:**
 - **Treasury:** -\$4B (Debt paid)
 - **Labor Unions:** -3 Approval (They hate cuts)
 - **Oligarchs:** +2 Approval (They love fiscal responsibility)
 - **Civil Unrest:** +2 (People are angry)

Option B: "Tax the Rich" Emergency Act

Emergency levy on corporate profits to cover the debt.

- **Financial Cost:** \$0 (You raise the money instantly)
- **Political Capital Cost:** 3 PC (High cost; you are fighting powerful lobbyists)
- **Outcomes:**
 - **Treasury:** -\$4B (Debt paid, covered by tax) -> Net -\$1B actually (keep some surplus)
 - **Labor Unions:** +2 Approval (They love this)
 - **Oligarchs:** -4 Approval (They are furious)
 - **Civil Unrest:** 0 (Change)

Option C: Print Money / Ignore Debt

Refuse to pay and print money to cover domestic costs.

- **Financial Cost:** \$0
- **Political Capital Cost:** 0 PC (Easy to do, hard to survive)
- **Outcomes:**
 - **Treasury:** +\$2B (Printed money)
 - **Labor Unions:** -1 Approval (Inflation fears)
 - **Oligarchs:** -3 Approval (Market panic)
 - **Military:** -2 Approval (Their budget is now worthless)
 - **Civil Unrest:** +4 (Panic buying)

Option D: The Corrupt Deal

Accept a bribe from a foreign superpower to pay the debt in exchange for military bases.

- **Financial Cost:** \$0
 - **Political Capital Cost:** +2 PC (The superpower gives you resources/propaganda help)
 - **Outcomes:**
 - **Treasury:** -\$4B (Debt paid by foreign aid)
 - **Labor Unions:** -1 Approval
 - **Oligarchs:** +1 Approval
 - **Military:** -3 Approval (They hate foreign troops on soil)
 - **Hidden Stat: Sovereignty** drops to "Vassal State"
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4. The Resolution Phase (How to Play)

1. **Pick an Option:** Let's say you choose **Option B (Tax the Rich)**.
2. **Check Affordability:** Do you have the **3 PC** required? Yes, you start with 5.
 - *New PC:* 2
3. **Update Factions:**
 - *Labor:* $6 + 2 = 8/10$ (Loyal)
 - *Oligarchs:* $4 - 4 = 0/10$ (Openly Hostile)
 - *Military:* Unchanged (5/10)
4. **Update Unrest:** Remains at 2/10.

5. The Consequence Logic (The "Engine")

Now, you must run a "State Check" to see if the game ends or changes.

- **Check 1: Bankruptcy?** Treasury is positive. (Pass)
- **Check 2: Coup D'etat?** Is Military support below 2? No. (Pass)
- **Check 3: Assassination/Capital Flight?**
 - *Rule:* If Oligarchs hit 0/10, they trigger a "Capital Flight" event.
 - *Consequence:* Next turn, your tax income is permanently reduced by 50%.

The Narrative Result:

"You saved the budget and pleased the workers, but the Oligarchs have declared war on your administration. Major factories are closing as they move assets offshore. Your treasury is safe for now, but your future income is destroyed."

Here is the Python implementation of that paper prototype. You can run this code directly in any Python environment (IDLE, PyCharm, or an online compiler like Replit) to play the scenario.

This script demonstrates the core **"State → Choice → Consequence"** loop.

The Python Prototype (**political_sim_prototype.py**)

Python

import time

class Country:

def __init__(self):

1. The Core Resources

self.treasury = 5 # In Billions

self.political_capital = 5 # Points (0-10)

self.civil_unrest = 2 # (0-10), 10 = Revolution

2. The Factions (0-10 Scale)

self.factions = {

"Labor": 6,

"Oligarchs": 4,

"Military": 5

}

Flags for game over or special states

self.game_over = False

self.modifiers = [] # Permanent effects (e.g., "Capital Flight")

def print_status(self):

print("\n" + "="*30)

print(f"| TREASURY: \${self.treasury}B")

print(f"| POLITICAL CAPITAL: {self.political_capital}/10")

print(f"| CIVIL UNREST: {self.civil_unrest}/10")

print("-" * 30)

print("| FACTION SUPPORT:")

for name, score in self.factions.items():

status = "Loyal" if score > 7 else "Hostile" if score < 3 else "Neutral"

print(f"| {name}: {score}/10 ({status})")

print("="*30 + "\n")

def modify_faction(self, faction_name, amount):

Helper to keep stats within 0-10

self.factions[faction_name] = max(0, min(10, self.factions[faction_name] + amount))

def modify_unrest(self, amount):

self.civil_unrest = max(0, min(10, self.civil_unrest + amount))

def run_turn(country):

print("EVENT: THE IMF DEMANDS REPAYMENT")

print("The IMF demands \$4 Billion immediately. You have \$5 Billion.")

print("Ignoring this destroys your credit rating.\n")

print("CHOOSE YOUR APPROACH:")

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print("[1] AUSTERITY: Slash spending. (Cost: 1 PC)")
print("[2] TAX THE RICH: Emergency corporate levy. (Cost: 3 PC)")
print("[3] PRINT MONEY: Ignore debt, print cash. (Cost: 0 PC)")
print("[4] CORRUPT DEAL: Accept foreign bribe. (Gain: +2 PC)")

choice = input("\nEnter choice (1-4): ")

# LOGIC ENGINE
if choice == "1": # AUSTERITY
    if country.political_capital < 1:
        print("\n✗ NOT ENOUGH POLITICAL CAPITAL! You are a Lame Duck.")
        return

    country.political_capital -= 1
    country.treasury -= 4
    country.modify_faction("Labor", -3)
    country.modify_faction("Oligarchs", +2)
    country.modify_unrest(+2)
    print("\n> You slashed the budget. The markets are happy, but the people are furious.")

elif choice == "2": # TAX THE RICH
    if country.political_capital < 3:
        print("\n✗ NOT ENOUGH POLITICAL CAPITAL! Lobbyists blocked the bill.")
        return

    country.political_capital -= 3
    country.treasury -= 1 # Paid 4, but gained tax revenue, net loss small
    country.modify_faction("Labor", +2)
    country.modify_faction("Oligarchs", -4)
    print("\n> You taxed the rich. The debt is paid, but the Oligarchs are plotting revenge.")

elif choice == "3": # PRINT MONEY
    country.treasury += 2 # Fake money
    country.modify_faction("Labor", -1) # Inflation fears
    country.modify_faction("Oligarchs", -3) # Market panic
    country.modify_faction("Military", -2) # Budget worthless
    country.modify_unrest(+4)
    print("\n> Money printer goes brrr. The debt is 'ignored', but inflation is skyrocketing.")

elif choice == "4": # CORRUPT DEAL
    country.political_capital += 2
    country.treasury -= 4 # Debt paid by them
    country.modify_faction("Military", -3)
    country.modify_faction("Labor", -1)
    country.modifiers.append("Vassal State")
    print("\n> You took the deal. The debt is gone, but foreign troops are now on your soil.")

else:

```

```

    print("Invalid choice.")
    return

# CONSEQUENCE CHECKER
check_game_state(country)

def check_game_state(country):
    print("\n--- CONSEQUENCES ---")

    # 1. Check Bankruptcy
    if country.treasury < 0:
        print("⚠️ STATE BANKRUPTCY: The government has collapsed.")
        country.game_over = True

    # 2. Check Coup (Military < 2)
    if country.factions["Military"] < 2:
        print("⚠️ MILITARY COUP: Tanks are surrounding the palace!")
        country.game_over = True

    # 3. Check Capital Flight (Oligarchs < 2)
    if country.factions["Oligarchs"] < 2:
        print("⚠️ CAPITAL FLIGHT: Businesses are fleeing the country! Tax revenue halved.")
        country.modifiers.append("Capital Flight")

    # 4. Check Revolution (Unrest > 8)
    if country.civil_unrest > 8:
        print("⚠️ REVOLUTION: The people are storming the capital!")
        country.game_over = True

    if not country.game_over:
        print("✅ You survived the turn.")

    # Show final stats
    country.print_status()

# --- MAIN LOOP ---
game_country = Country()
game_country.print_status()
run_turn(game_country)

```

What this proves

You don't need fancy graphics yet. This code confirms that **Interconnected Systems** (where one choice affects multiple variables) create the most tension.

- **Taxing the rich** solves the money problem but creates an economic one (Capital Flight).

- **Printing money** solves the immediate pinch but spikes Unrest, pushing you closer to Game Over.

you need to implement a **Dynamic Game Loop**. You want the player to feel like they are steering a massive ship: difficult to turn, hard to stop, and dangerous if you ignore the warning lights.

Here is the gameplay architecture required to make it work well.

1. The Core Loop: "Crisis vs. Investment"

A great political sim balances two types of actions: **Reactive (Firefighting)** and **Proactive (Building)**.

The Cycle of a Turn

1. **The Morning Briefing (Reactive):** The game throws a problem at you (The Crisis Deck). You *must* deal with this.
 - *Example:* "A bridge collapsed." (Do you pay to fix it, ignore it, or blame the previous administration?)
2. **The Action Phase (Proactive):** You spend your remaining Political Capital on your *own* agenda.
 - *Example:* You promised "Free Healthcare" in your election. Now is the time to pass the law.
3. **The Simulation Step:** The game calculates the math.
 - *Inputs:* Your Crisis choice + Your New Law + Economy.
 - *Outputs:* Approval ratings update, Budget updates.
4. **The Feedback Phase:** The world changes visibly. (Newspapers print headlines, the map changes color).

Why this works: It creates tension. "I *want* to pass Free Healthcare (Proactive), but the Bridge Collapse (Reactive) used up all my budget!"

2. The "Living Deck" System (Narrative Design)

Don't just have a random list of events. Implement a **Reactive Deck**. This is how you make the game feel like it remembers the player's choices.

- **The Standard Deck:** Generic cards that can happen anytime (e.g., "Flu Season," "Stock Market Dip").
- **The Triggered Deck:** Cards that only get added based on your choices.

Gameplay Example:

- **Turn 1:** There is a protest. You choose to send in the **Riot Police**.
- **The Mechanic:** The game secretly adds the "*Police Brutality Scandal*" card to the deck. It might not happen immediately, but it is now "in the pool."

- **Turn 4:** You draw the *"Police Brutality Scandal"* card.
 - *Flavor Text:* "Video footage has surfaced of the crackdown you ordered in Turn 1."
 - *Impact:* You lose massive support from Liberals.

Design Tip: This prevents the game from feeling random. When a scandal hits, the player realizes, *"Oh, this is because of what I did three turns ago."*

3. The "Policy Web" (The Strategy Layer)

If events are the "battles," Policies are the "war." This is your "Tech Tree."

Instead of researching "Lasers," you research **Laws**.

- **Categories:** Welfare, Economy, Order, Foreign Policy.
- **The Cost:** Laws cost **Political Capital** (to pass) and **Budget** (to maintain).
- **The Interaction:** Policies should have "Gravity."

Example: Passing "The Surveillance Act"

- *Immediate Effect:* Terrorist attacks drop by 50%.
- *Ongoing Cost:* -\$1B per turn (Data centers).
- *Side Effect:* "Liberty" stat drops. If Liberty gets too low, a new faction spawns: **The Rebels**.

Gameplay Hook: Policies take time to implement. You sign the bill in Turn 2, but the benefits don't start until Turn 5. Can you survive long enough to see your plan work?

4. Visualizing the Data: The "Map as Dashboard"

You want to avoid spreadsheet fatigue. The best way to do this is to make the Map your primary UI.

- **Regional Politics:** Divide your country into 5-6 regions (e.g., The Industrial North, The Agricultural South, The Coastal Cities).
- **Visual Indicators:**
 - *Is the North angry?* Don't show a number. Make the region glow **Red** on the map.
 - *Is the economy booming?* Show tiny trucks moving faster on the roads.
 - *Is there high crime?* Show police siren icons blinking in the cities.
- **Gameplay Mechanic:** You can target specific regions.
 - *Scenario:* You need to win the election, but the "Agricultural South" hates you.
 - *Action:* Pass a "Farm Subsidy" bill. You see the South turn from Red to Green on the map, but the "Industrial North" turns Yellow (annoyed) because their taxes paid for it.

5. The "Cabinet" Minigame

You are the leader, but you need Ministers to execute your will. This adds a layer of **Personnel Management**.

- **The Mechanic:** You have 5 slots (Economy, Defense, Foreign, Interior, Welfare).
 - **The Dilemma:**
 - **Minister A (The Expert):** +10% Economy efficiency, but Low Loyalty (might leak scandals to the press).
 - **Minister B (The Loyalist):** High Loyalty (covers up your crimes), but Incompetent (-5% Economy efficiency).
 - **Gameplay Interaction:**
 - When a crisis happens (e.g., "Market Crash"), you can **Blame the Minister**.
 - You fire them. You survive the anger, but you lose their bonuses.
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6. Winning and Losing

Political games are unique because "Game Over" isn't always death. It's irrelevance.

- **Victory:** There is no "You Win" screen. There is only "Re-election" or "Legacy."
 1. **Goal:** Survive 2 terms (8 years/40 turns). At the end, you get a "History Book" summary. *"President X is remembered as a tyrant who fixed the economy but destroyed civil rights."*
- **Defeat:**
 1. **Lost Election:** You serve out your term as a "Lame Duck" (limited actions) and watch the new guy undo your laws.
 2. **Impeachment:** Triggered by high corruption or low PC.
 3. **Coup/Revolution:** Triggered by low Military support or high Unrest.

Summary of Gameplay Flow

1. **Look at Map:** See red zones (problems).
2. **Draw Card:** A crisis hits! (e.g., Hurricane in the South).
3. **Make Choice:** Send aid? (Costs Budget). Ignore? (Increases Unrest).
4. **Action Phase:** Spend PC to pass "Green Energy Act" (Long term fix).
5. **End Turn:** Watch the simulation update. Did the South stop glowing red? Did the budget hold?

Next Step: To flesh this out, we need to design the **Factions** deeply. A generic "Public" is boring. We need specific groups with specific desires that *conflict*.

Conflict.

You need to design factions that are mathematically designed to hate each other. This ensures the player can never please everyone.

1. The Faction Triangle (The Core Conflict)

Instead of a simple "Left vs. Right" line, visualize a triangle. Every policy you pass pulls the country toward one corner, inevitably pulling it away from the other two.

Corner A: The Capitalists (The Oligarchy)

- **Desires:** Low taxes, deregulation, privatization, open trade.
- **Leverage:** *The Economy*. If they are unhappy, they trigger "Capital Flight" (Budget drops).
- **Natural Enemy:** The Workers (who want high wages).

Corner B: The Workers (The Unions)

- **Desires:** High minimum wage, strong safety nets, labor rights, protectionism.
- **Leverage:** *Productivity*. If they are unhappy, they trigger "General Strikes" (Economy halts).
- **Natural Enemy:** The Capitalists (who want low costs).

Corner C: The State (The Nationalists/Military)

- **Desires:** High military spending, border control, surveillance, obedience.
- **Leverage:** *Order*. If they are unhappy, they trigger "Coups" or allow crime to spike.
- **Natural Enemy:** *Civil Liberties* (often overlaps with Liberals or Intellectuals).

The Gameplay Hook:

You cannot move to the center.

- If you raise taxes to fund the Military (pleasing the State), you anger the Capitalists.
- If you cut taxes to please Capitalists, you must cut funding, angering the State (Military) and Workers (Welfare).
- **The player is constantly juggling these three balls.**

2. The "Swing" Factions (The Wildcards)

To make the game deeper than just "Red vs. Blue," you add smaller, volatile groups that act as kingmakers. These groups care about specific *cultural* issues rather than just economics.

1. The Religious Traditionalists

- **Care about:** Tradition, banning vices (gambling/drugs), education curriculum.
- **Economic Stance:** Neutral. They will ally with *anyone* who protects their values.
- **Gameplay Role:** You can "buy" their votes. If you are failing economically, you can pass a "Traditional Family Act" to win their support without spending money.

2. The Intellectuals / Liberals

- **Care about:** Free speech, science funding, secularism, civil rights.
- **Economic Stance:** Mixed.

- **Gameplay Role:** They control the "Tech Tree." If they hate you, your research into new policies (like "Green Energy" or "Digital Banking") slows down because the experts are leaving the country (Brain Drain).

3. The Minorities / Separatists

- **Care about:** Autonomy, anti-discrimination, regional funding.
- **Gameplay Role:** The "Time Bomb." If ignored for too long, they don't just protest; they start a Rebellion or demand independence for a specific region on your map.

3. Mechanic: Satisfaction vs. Power

This is a critical distinction that many games miss. A faction has two stats:

1. **Approval (How much they like you):** 0-100%
2. **Power (How dangerous they are):** 0-100%

The Strategy:

You don't always need to make people happy. Sometimes, you just need to make them weak.

- **Scenario:** The Unions hate you (0% Approval) because you cut wages.
- **Strategy A (Appeasement):** Raise the minimum wage. (Approval goes up, Economy hurts).
- **Strategy B (Suppression):** Pass a "Restrictions on Striking" bill or arrest Union leaders.
 - *Result:* Their Approval drops even lower (they hate you), but their **Power** drops to 0. They *can't* hurt you anymore.
 - *Risk:* This creates "Underground Resistance" (Terrorism risk increases).

4. The Interaction Matrix (The Math Behind the Scenes)

When you design a policy, you map it against these groups.

Example Policy: "Robotics Automation Subsidy"

- *Flavor:* Government pays companies to replace factory workers with robots.

Faction	Impact on Approval	Impact on Power	Reason
Capitalists	+20 (Love it)	+10 (Stronger)	Lower costs, higher profits.

Workers	-30 (Hate it)	-15 (Weaker)	They lose jobs, and unemployed people have less leverage.
Intellectuals	+5 (Like it)	+5 (Stronger)	Supports tech progress.
State	+5 (Like it)	0	Higher GDP means more tax revenue for the army.

The Gameplay Result:

This policy is a "Trap" for new players. It looks great (Economy goes up!), but it tanks Worker support while simultaneously making the Capitalists too powerful. If the Capitalists get too powerful, they might start dictating laws to you.

5. Next Steps: The "Ecosystem"

Now that you have the Factions, you need a world for them to live in. We need to define the **Global Superpowers** surrounding your country.

In real politics, small countries are often puppets of larger ones.

- **Empire A (The Capitalist Superpower):** Demands you privatize everything.
- **Empire B (The Socialist Superpower):** Demands you nationalize everything.

External Politics.

In a good political simulator, foreign policy is not just about "declaring war." It is about **Survival**. Small and medium nations are often buffeted by the waves of larger superpowers. This layer creates the feeling that you are not entirely in control.

Here is how to design a deep Geopolitical System.

1. The "Sphere of Influence" Mechanic

Do not create 200 generic countries. Create **2 Superpowers** and **3-4 Neighbors**. This is all the cognitive load a player can handle.

The Alignment Slider

Instead of "Relationship points" (0-100), use a **Tug-of-War** bar.

- **Superpower A (The Empire):** Represents Capitalism, Military Power.
- **Superpower B (The Union):** Represents Socialism, Collectivism.
- **You:** In the middle.

The Gameplay Loop:

- **The Bait:** Superpower A offers you a "Development Loan" (\$5 Billion).
- **The Catch:** Accepting it moves your Alignment marker toward them.
- **The Consequence:**
 - **Short term:** You get money to fix your internal crisis.
 - **Long term:** You are now "Aligned." Superpower B places sanctions on you (Economy drops). Superpower A demands you build a military base for them (Sovereignty drops).

2. Sovereignty: The "Game Over" Creep

This is a unique mechanic for political sims. **Sovereignty** is a resource (0-100%).

- **100% Sovereignty:** You can pass any law you want.
- **50% Sovereignty:** The Superpower ambassador calls you every 5 turns with a "Request" you cannot refuse without massive penalties.
- **0% Sovereignty: Game Over.** You have been annexed or turned into a puppet state. The game ends with a screen saying, *"You remain President in name only. The Ambassador runs the country."*

Why this is fun: It forces the player to make "Deal with the Devil" choices. You *need* the foreign aid to stop a famine, but accepting it costs you 10% Sovereignty. How much of your freedom are you willing to sell?

3. Trade as a Weapon (The "Achilles Heel")

Don't simulate complex goods chains. Simulate **Dependencies**.

Give your country **1 Critical Weakness** and **1 Critical Strength**.

- **Your Strength (Export):** Rare Earth Metals.
 - *Gameplay:* You can threaten to cut off supply to the Superpowers to make them listen to you.
- **Your Weakness (Import):** Food or Energy.
 - *Gameplay:* If you anger your neighbor (who sells you oil), they turn off the tap.
 - *Result:* "Energy Crisis." Factories close, lights go out, **Civil Unrest** spikes instantly.

The Dilemma:

"The neighbor who sells us Oil is committing human rights violations. If I sanction them (Moral Choice), they cut the oil, and my people freeze (Political Suicide). If I ignore it, the Liberals hate me."

4. Espionage: The "Invisible Hand"

Foreign powers shouldn't just be lines on a map; they should mess with your internal Factions.

The Mechanic: Foreign Funding.

- If you drift too close to **Socialism**, the Capitalist Superpower secretly funds your **Opposition Party**.
 - **Visual Feedback:** You notice the "Oligarchs" faction gaining **Power** randomly, even though you haven't helped them.
 - **Player Reaction:** You have to spend your own Political Capital to investigate foreign interference or crack down on NGOs.
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Phase 4: Bringing it all together (The UI/UX)

Now that you have all these systems (Internal Factions, Economy, Geopolitics), the risk is **Information Overload**. A good simulator lives or dies by its Interface.

You need a **"War Room" Aesthetic**.

1. The Desk (The Hub)

Don't use a standard game menu. Make the main screen the Leader's Desk.

- **The Newspaper:** Click to see the narrative/headlines (Public Opinion).
- **The Phone:** Flashing red light means a Crisis/Superpower call.
- **The Map:** On the wall. Shows the data overlay.
- **The Dossier:** Confidential reports on your Ministers/Factions.

2. Visualizing Complex Data

Do not force players to read spreadsheets. Use **Visual Metaphors**.

- **The Treasury:** Represented by a jar or vault. If it's low, show cobwebs or moths.
 - **Faction Happiness:**
 - *Happy:* The Union leader is smiling in his portrait.
 - *Angry:* The Union leader is scowling.
 - *Plotting:* The Union leader is shadowed or turned away.
 - **The "Pipe" System (Economy):**
 - Show money flowing like water through pipes.
 - **Taxes -> Treasury -> Services.**
 - If you have "Corruption," show a leak in the pipe where money drips out before reaching the Treasury.
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Phase 5: The "Law Tree" (Progression)

Finally, players need a sense of progression. This is usually done through a "Tech Tree," but in a political game, it's a **Constitution/Law Tree**.

Organize it by ideology, not just utility.

Branch 1: The Welfare State

- *Tier 1:* Minimum Wage.
- *Tier 2:* Universal Healthcare.
- *Tier 3:* Universal Basic Income (UBI).
- *Ultimate:* Post-Scarcity Society.

Branch 2: The Police State

- *Tier 1:* Increased Police Budget.
- *Tier 2:* Facial Recognition Cameras.
- *Tier 3:* Internet Censorship.
- *Ultimate:* Totalitarian Surveillance.

Branch 3: The Free Market

- *Tier 1:* Tax Breaks.
- *Tier 2:* Privatized Schools.
- *Tier 3:* Abolish Minimum Wage.
- *Ultimate:* Anarcho-Capitalism (The State only exists to protect property).

Mechanic: You can mix and match, but some laws block others. You cannot have "Universal Basic Income" (High Cost) AND "Zero Corporate Tax" (Low Income) without bankrupting the country.

A Next Step for You

You now have the complete skeleton of the game:

1. **Factions** (The Triangle).
2. **Loop** (Crisis vs. Action).
3. **World** (Superpowers & Sovereignty).
4. **Progression** (The Law Tree).

State of the Nation.

Here are four distinct starting scenarios. They function as difficulty settings but also change the *flavor* of the gameplay entirely.

1. The Post-War Recovery (Hard Mode)

You are the first elected leader after a devastating 5-year civil war. The guns are silent, but the country is in ruins.

- **Starting Stats:**
 - **Treasury:** Near Zero (Infrastructure is destroyed).

- **Unrest:** Very High (8/10).
- **Political Capital:** High (You are a war hero/symbol of hope).
- **Factions:** Extremist. There is no center. Everyone is either a Radical Socialist or a Hardline Nationalist.
- **Unique Mechanic: "Reconciliation"**
 - You have a hidden "Tension" meter. If you favor one side too much, the Civil War restarts (Game Over).
 - *Challenge:* You must rebuild the economy without looking like you are punishing the losing side of the war.
- **Win Condition:** Survive 10 years without the war restarting and rebuild GDP to pre-war levels.

2. The Resource Curse (The "Golden Handcuffs")

Oil (or a rare mineral) has been discovered! The money is pouring in, but so are the sharks.

- **Starting Stats:**
 - **Treasury:** Overflowing (Billions in surplus).
 - **Corruption:** High (Everyone is stealing).
 - **Sovereignty:** Low (Superpowers are watching you like hawks).
 - **Factions:** The Oligarchs are incredibly powerful; the People are poor but expecting a payout.
- **Unique Mechanic: "The Dutch Disease"**
 - Because you export so much oil, your other industries (farming, manufacturing) are dying.
 - *Challenge:* Use the oil money to diversify the economy before the oil price crashes (which is a random event). If the price crashes and you haven't diversified, you collapse.
- **Win Condition:** Reduce oil dependence to <50% of GDP while maintaining high approval.

3. The Technocrat's Dream (Normal / Sandbox)

A stable, developed nation with a stagnating economy. No guns, no famine, just boredom and bureaucracy.

- **Starting Stats:**
 - **Treasury:** Stable.
 - **Unrest:** Low.
 - **Bureaucracy:** High (Everything costs double Political Capital to do).
 - **Factions:** Apathetic. Voter turnout is low.
- **Unique Mechanic: "The Gerontocracy"**
 - Your population is aging. Pension costs increase by 5% every turn automatically.
 - *Challenge:* You must pass unpopular reforms (cutting pensions, raising retirement age) or encourage immigration (which angers Nationalists) to save the budget.
- **Win Condition:** Solve the demographic crisis and win re-election.

4. The Emergency State (Survival Mode)

You take office the day a massive pandemic (or natural disaster) hits.

- **Starting Stats:**
 - **Treasury:** Dropping fast (-\$1B per turn).
 - **Health/Safety:** Critical.
 - **Political Capital:** Variable (People are rallying 'round the flag, but panic is high).
 - **Unique Mechanic: "The Panic Meter"**
 - Normal politics are suspended. You can pass radical laws (Curfews, Nationalization) easily, but if the "Panic" drops, people will suddenly realize you took away their rights.
 - *Challenge:* Manage the crisis without becoming a permanent dictator.
 - **Win Condition:** End the emergency state and restore civil liberties.
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Designing the "Custom Scenario" Tool

For replayability, allow players to build their own nightmare.

The Slider System:

1. **Economy:** [Bankrupt <---> Rich]
2. **Liberty:** [Police State <---> Anarchy]
3. **Corruption:** [Honest <---> Kleptocracy]
4. **Superpower Interest:** [Ignored <---> Proxy War Battleground]

The "Perks & Flaws" Trait System: Give the Leader (the Player) RPG-style traits that affect the math.

- **Charismatic:** +1 Political Capital per turn.
 - **Paranoid:** -10% chance of Assassination, but Minister Loyalty drops faster.
 - **Economist:** Can see hidden projected stats for the budget, but -5 approval with Religious groups (seen as soulless).
 - **General:** Starts with high Military support, but Liberals distrust you immediately.
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One Final "Secret Sauce": The End Game

How you end the game is just as important as how you start. Avoid a simple "Game Over" screen.

The "Legacy" System: When the player loses or finishes their term, generate a newspaper obituary or history book excerpt based on their stats.

- *If you fixed the economy but crushed liberty:*
"President [Name] is remembered as the 'Architect of Order.' Trains ran on time, but few dared to speak on them."
 - *If you were democratic but the economy failed:*
"President [Name] was a well-meaning soul who presided over the Great Collapse. A kind leader, but a weak one."
 - *If you were corrupt:*
"President [Name] is currently living in exile in the Swiss Alps, enjoying a fortune that vanished from the treasury in 2026."
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Summary of the Design Document

You now have a full roadmap:

1. **Core Loop:** Crisis (Card Deck) -> Decision -> Simulation Update.
2. **Stats:** PC, Treasury, Unrest, Factions (Triangle).
3. **World:** Superpowers, Sovereignty, Trade.
4. **Progression:** The Law Tree.
5. **Scenarios:** Distinct starting states.

Would you like to try writing one "Complex Event Chain"?